Washington's Farewell Address

President George Washington · September 19, 1796

Source: George Washington, Farewell Address (1796). Public domain. Continuous passages.

> Declining a third term, Washington warned the young nation against the divisive “spirit of party” and against “permanent alliances” with foreign powers — advice that shaped American politics for generations.

baneful effects of the spirit of party, generally. This spirit, unfortunately, is inseparable from our nature, having its root in the strongest passions of the human mind. It exists under different shapes in all governments, more or less stifled, controlled, or repressed; but, in those of the popular form, it is seen in its greatest rankness and is truly their worst enemy.

[. . .]

The great rule of conduct for us in regard to foreign nations is, in extending our commercial relations, to have with them as little political connection as possible. So far as we have already formed engagements, let them be fulfilled with perfect good faith. Here let us stop.